caused massive destruction of the infrastructure, though loss of lives was less than what was feared. The reconstruction process is on, with the army, air force and other agencies lending a helping hand.

Insurgency, terrorism and militancy are getting out of fashion, and the world has got united against terror. The 30 million people of the northeast are fed up of the strife and violence of the past five to six decades. They aspire for peace and prosperity in their part of the world. They need good governance and the connectivity to be able to engage with the global economy, as they are landlocked at present. The fact that Southeast Asia begins from the northeast should be remembered by the national leadership and our policy planners.

The prime minister has stated that Naxal extremism is one of the most serious internal security threats faced by our country. Lack of governance and many deep-rooted socioeconomic problems have led to a major law and order problem in thirty-four districts of eight states in the heartland of our country. In all, a total of eighty-seven districts in nine states are affected by Naxals or Maoists in some form or the other.[9] This area is often referred to as the 'red corridor' or the 'Compact Revolutionary Zone'. Interestingly, the worst-effected areas are the most remote, thickly forested and underdeveloped. The natural resources, including minerals, in these areas are immense and mostly untapped. Various hues of left-wing extremists (LWE) have gotten together under one umbrella, and are espousing the causes that have the greatest appeal to the poor tribal people inhabiting these areas. Their stated aim is to 'overthrow the semi-colonial, semi-feudal system under neo-colonial form of indirect rule'.[10] The nerve centre of this zone is the Dandakaranya forest area, which lies at the junction of Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, Maharashtra, Orissa and Andhra Pradesh.

A rising power needs all the resources that are available in the country, and therefore, law and order and peace are essential in this resource-rich heartland of India. The government has adopted an integrated approach to tackle this threat. An empowered group of ministers under the home minister has been created to oversee a coordinated approach to counter the Naxalite violence. And a